as he was still sleepy. When asked, Sujaya Narayan could not confirm if Nalini had sneaked into the office on Sunday.

Past midnight, Kaarthikeyan was going through the progress of the investigation with Raju and DIG Sri Kumar, another member of the SIT, in his cabin. He had a chart on the wall displaying the developments until then. It was already the end of May, and he only had a photograph of the human bomb and a man in a kurta pyjama as a suspect. Of the two, the human bomb was dead.

'We have information that they are associated with this Nalini girl we are looking for,' pointed out Raju.

'Yes, Raju, but she has fled from her Villivakkam house.' Kaarthikeyan said.

Sri Kumar joined in. 'We now know that the pellets used in the explosive device used by the human bomb were similar to the pellets found in the unexploded SFG-87 grenade recovered from the site of Padmanabha's killing. That links the two assassinations, sir.'

'Yes, and that's a fabulous job done by the NSG and our own SIT.'

Kaarthikeyan had gone back to his chart. He pointed to the place where two names were written—David and Raghuvaran. However, the slots of their photos were still blank. Referring to that, Sri Kumar spoke again.

'Sri, we do have the names of Padmanabha's killers, David and Raghuvaran. But we do not have their photographs. Their names are not of much use, as you know.'

'Agreed, sir.'

'We are still groping in the dark while expectations are rising.'

Later that day, a grey Ambassador drove Sri Kumar out of the building. As the tail light of the car diminished, a silhouette appeared from a bush in the front courtyard and quietly scaled the six-foot-high wall of Malligai. The two sentries posted at the main gate were oblivious to what was going on. The figure landed on the sidewalk outside. The streetlight that fell on the figure showed a man, probably in his twenties, frail of body, with a dark complexion. A lot like the LTTE boys whose photographs were seen in